of our people were not at peace, for one party was continually working to break up the army, and the other to keep it together." A good number of the lower-ranked Crusaders deserted. Shortly after Easter, 1203, the whole army left for Corfu, where they would meet Alexius; as they departed, they destroyed the city behind them.[7]

It was late June before the entire fleet finally reached the Bosphorus Strait. Young Alexius had apparently convinced them that the people of Constantinople would immediately rally to him, and that any fighting would be brief. Instead, the city closed against him. The Crusader army was forced to lay siege to it.

As sieges go, it was a brief one. The attack began on July 5. Ten days later, the first Crusader knights managed to scale the walls and enter the city. They were driven back, but a second assault then began, with Venetian warships hurling stones and arrows from the water while scaling ladders were put into place. "The din was so tremendous," says Villehardouin, "that it seemed as if both land and sea were crumbling." The attackers finally broke into the city itself, driving the panicked inhabitants in front of them. To block the approach of the emperor's royal guard, they set the city on fire.[8]

That night, the emperor packed up his treasures and fled from the city. The blinded Isaac Angelus was sprung from prison by his supporters within the city, and by morning he was back in his palace, sitting on his throne.

There was a very brief respite of rejoicing, during which young Alexius was crowned as his father's co-ruler; and then the Crusade derailed permanently.

Alexius, aware that his uncle still had partisans in the city, was afraid that the exiled usurper would return as soon as the Crusaders left. He offered to pay the army to stay until the following spring. Another argument erupted between the Crusader parties. In the end, they remained in Constantinople; but once again they were divided, bored, and aimless. They began to fight with the natives. A second fire, deliberately set by an unknown culprit, destroyed another huge swath of the city, this time wiping out the homes of the most powerful and wealthy inhabitants. Alexius, discovering that the royal treasury had been thoroughly raided, could pay his hired troops only by collecting special taxes. He tried breaking into the tombs of the previous emperors for their jewels, and even so could raise a mere fraction of the money needed. By January, everyone hated him.

Finally his own trusted lieutenant, a veteran named Mourtzouphlus, led a midnight raid on the young emperor's bedchamber and took him prisoner. With the full support of the Byzantine army, he declared himself emperor, taking the name Alexius V Ducas. Old Isaac, now almost entirely senile, died